

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness: Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - Elements and Charnel Ground Contemplations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 19:46

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I do wish it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we are continuing with our passage through the discourse on the foundations or the establishment of mindfulness. And we're looking at the body. The first section is the body, and we've been through the breath, using the breath for mindfulness and seeing mainly impermanence. The four postures and then full awareness, which basically is daily life practice. Then we have the body parts to overcome any sense of disgust with the body. Remember, it's about being disenchanted.

And so there are two more sections, one is called the elements and one is called the nine charnel grounds, so these elements. I think this runs across the ancient world actually. They say they determine four different characteristics, from which the mind built up some image some feeling et cetera. And they were earth, which is to do with pressure and lightness; fire, which is to do with heat, cold, and warmth; water, which is elasticity, cohesiveness, so it also is stiffness; and air or wind. Sometimes it's wind, which is motion or again, stillness.

These were meant to be investigated when we actually meditate. Now, it's pretty clear to see that when we're doing touch, on the feeling of touch. We'll come to it in a minute. With eyesight, I mean, it's the subatomic particles, which is quite amazing, really, when you think about it, to be sensitive to subatomic particles. Photons, light, maybe heat, but it's not really discussed. The ears definitely pressure, definitely the pressure of sound waves. And that's actually all you get at the ear drum. That's the sense base. Everything else is done by what's known as the mind door or the whole process within the mind itself, turning it into a sound, giving it a meaning, et cetera. When it comes to taste and smell, that's even more subtle in a way. I don't think they pertain so clearly to that, although things like pressure, heat, I mean that's obvious when you're eating, but the more subtle sensations I think really aren't explained by these four, but that's just a personal understanding.

If you want to have the traditional understanding, it's in the *Visuddhimagga*, The Path of Purification by

Buddhaghosa. There's a whole section there if you want it. So that's a big tome. It's probably one of the greatest, one of the great spiritual works of the world, of any spiritual tradition. It holds not only the understanding of the Buddha, but also all the practices. So it's quite a compendium. You wouldn't want to read it from the first page to the end. There's about a thousand pages. But as an encyclopedia of spiritual practice and understanding, it really is quite extraordinary. Buddhaghosa. It was compiled, I think, in our Middle Ages, about 500s or so.

Okay, so what it says is that the meditator reviews the same body, however it is placed, however disposed as consisting of elements. In this body, there's the earth element, the water element, fire element and the air element, just as though a skilled butcher and his apprentice had killed a cow and was seated at a crossroads with it cut up in pieces. So a *bhikkhu*, a meditator reviews this same body as consisting of the elements. So just as a butcher, you know, whatever, the leg or the head or whatever, yeah, so you understand that.

So this comes into play when we're practicing *vipassanā*. For instance if you have a pain in the knee for instance when you're meditating or discomfort in the knee or whatever so as it draws your attention you go to it and your first word will be say pain right so you're saying pain this is pain this is what pain feels like and then when you're established there and you make sure that the aversion to the pain has disappeared completely so you're entirely equanimous with the pain. You then, as it were, absorb into the pain. You go into the pain to deconstruct it, right? To find out what are the sensations that constitute this concept of pain. And of course, when you go in there, you'll find things like pressure or heat or a combination of little sensations. And at that level, of course, there's no concept of pain, so there's no suffering, right? You've deconstructed it.

So that's the level of direct perception at the sense base. So this is where the Buddha talks about the point of contact. For those of you who know dependent origination, the psychology of the Buddha. So at the point of contact, there has to be an object, there has to be a sense base, so the five senses, including the mind, the sixth sense, because that's the one that the emotions and thoughts appear upon. And also this basic information from all the other senses appear upon the mind door, as it's called.

The object, the sense base and consciousness. So consciousness is obviously there like a screen upon which this arises. If it doesn't arise on consciousness, the screen of consciousness, then you don't know it. I'm sure you've all had the experience of wondering where you got that bruise from or how you cut yourself because your mind was so involved in something you didn't actually notice how you got caught in a door or something or, you know, slight bruise, not a big one. And that means that that sensation didn't impact on the mind door.

So these four elements are really apparent to us when we really go into a sensation or feeling. Now it's the same with an emotion you see, deconstructing an emotion. What is an emotion before you give it a name? So you might find for instance anxiety or fear for instance and it is in you, you can feel it in your heart and

you draw your attention to it and then of course you've got to make sure the fear, the fear's gone, all the reaction's gone, the aversion's gone. And so you're left with the fear. Then you go into the fear. Now what is it you're actually feeling at that sense sensation base? You see it's not very much, some watery business, some fluidy stuff, some pressure. And of course by doing that you begin to undermine this fear of the fear when you realize actually it's just a compendium of these sensations. Okay so it does have a real purpose for insight.

And the second thing is, of course, that when you're at that level of perception, impermanence becomes more obvious. They're just arising and passing away all the time. So this is an important teaching about elements in the foundations there.

Now, the next one is the charnel ground. So it's always interesting this, by the way, in those days, they would just lay the bodies out in an open ground, and as you'll see from it that the local animals would eat it, they were shrouded in white. And it was these cloths that the mendicants, not just the Buddhists, not just the followers of the Buddha, but all mendicants used to take and sew into robes. And the Buddha simply followed that practice. Later on, when he had a group of monks and nuns around him, he wanted them to look a bit more tidy. So he asked them to cut this cloth in such ways that it recreated a paddy field. And you can probably see the lines on my robe here at the back here. So in between the sections there, the paddy fields and the narrow bits of the paths, the raised paths that sort of follow the paddy field round and you can walk around the paddy field. So you've got a very good robe there, that shows you. And to then boil them with an arachnid, which gave them a sort of brownie colour.

And then he went on to ask the orders to shave their hair off their head, you see. So all the others had matted hair, you know, dreadlocks. If you see the aesthetics of today that still exist today in India, you'll see that they've got matted locks. So it was cooler to have your hair off anyway in that sort of climate. So I think it was an effort to make his monks and nuns look a bit smart, you might say.

So again, because as though he were seeing a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground one, two, three days dead, bloated, livid and oozing matter. A *bhikkhu* compares this same body with it thus. This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate. So it's that connection, you see, to sit with this rotting corpse and to remind oneself that, well, you know, one day this is going to be like that.

By the way, the commentaries tell people not to sit windward. That's obviously a bit of good advice. Now in this way, he abides contemplating the body both internally and externally, et cetera.

And as though, again, as though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground devoured by crows, hawks, vultures, dogs, jackals, various kinds of worms. And again, this body, this body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

And as though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground, a skeleton with flesh and blood held together with sinews. A fleshless skeleton smeared with blood held together with sinews. A skeleton

without flesh and blood held together with sinews. Disconnected bones scattered in all directions. Here a hand bone, there a foot bone, here a shin bone, there a thigh bone, here a hip bone, there a back bone, here a rib bone, there a breast bone, here an arm bone, there a shoulder bone, here a neck bone, there a jaw bone, here a tooth, there a skull. And the *bhikkhu* compares this same body with it thus. This body too is the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

And then the final bit is a corpse thrown aside in the charnel grounds, bones bleached white, the color of shells, bones heaped up more than a year old, bones rotted and crumbled to dust. The *bhikkhu* compares the same body. This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.

So he's very big on death, the Buddha. I did, for those of you who are new to the evening, I did a whole section on death and the Buddha's teachings about death and how to do death contemplations in earlier videos. But here it's really grinding our nose in the dirt you might say and you can see from his explanation that he's done it, he's been there, he's sat with this lot and he's made those observations right. So this comes from his own personal experience without any doubt.

I don't know if you've actually seen a dead body, but it is definitely lifeless. And when you go to the East as a *bhikkhu*, as a monk or nun, you can go to the mortuary, you can go to the pathology department and see them cutting the body open and trying to find out why the person died, et cetera. And that's quite an experience.

My first experience with a dead body actually goes back to when I was about the age of 10. My father, my great aunt Florence, which is a lovely First World War name, isn't it, Florence? She died and my father asked me if I wanted to come and see the body. I was a 10 year old, of course, that did sound like an adventure. And when we got there, she was laid out, you see, and I just remember touching her forehead here. And it was very cold or cool, you know, and it moved, you know, like I thought it'd be stiff, but it moved. And I don't remember being particularly upset by it or anything like that. It was just a dead body.

But the next time I had an occasion with a dead body was I was at the Buddhist Vihara. I was already ordained actually, it was my first year. And I was at the Vihara in Birmingham, that's where I was staying. And we had a visit from some Christian monks from the St. Bernard's Abbey, which is near Birmingham. And they were picking up Tibetan monks who were staying with us. And it was part of this communication, you might say, between monks of different, well, between the Buddhist and the Christian monks. And he was an elderly man and he got hold of this huge case and carried it out to his car. As I came out from the gate, he was falling to the ground, calling for assistance, you see. So I put the bags down and ran over to him. And so I held him as he was lying down on the ground, you see. And he lost consciousness. And then he made this huge effort to come back, his eyes open and he's trying to come back. And then he just let go. And the weight of the body was quite obvious to me. I was thinking it's rather ironic that this wonderful Christian monk died with a Buddhist head as his last vision. And then the ambulance came 10 minutes later, but he was gone.

So when we have an occasion to be with somebody who's dying, this is a real teaching for us. I mean, that sounds a bit callous almost. I mean, you're there for the person who's dying, of course, but it does bring it to you. And to observe anything that's died, your pet that's died, that can be also quite a teaching too. Or anything that you see on the road that's been run over by a car. That also is a teaching of this finality, of this disappearance of the person. And what you're left with is, well, just a bag of bones, really.

So something that it's good to contemplate. Now, I do it every day this evening. I do the reflections on sickness, aging and death. It only takes a moment, but it just puts that sort of reality back in life, you know, that everything is coming to an end. And quite paradoxically, you think you'd get depressed if you brought that to mind. But of course, it brings you into the present moment and the sheer miracle of being here, the sheer miracle of being awake, of being aware. And the effort then is to make the most of it. So the contemplation of death, however you do it, has great benefits. And also, of course, in the final hour, we remind ourselves, my mother died, my father died. Everybody's been there. The Buddha died, for heaven's sake. And that gives you the courage to go through the gate.

So, yes, do contemplation of sickness aging and death at least for a little moment every day. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not created too much confusion and that by your practice you will be liberated from suffering sooner rather than later. Just in case I forget by the way, all those of you who've joined because of the lockdown, you are, of course, welcome to join me every evening because this will go on until the end of lockdown, whenever that is. I'm hoping it won't be next year, that's all.

Very good. So I'll start with the Refuges and Precepts.

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